

THE HOPECORE PROJECT

3D Modeling Software Guide

Complete list — Fully Free, Freemium & Professional Paid tools — 2026

FULLY FREE / OPEN SOURCE — No Limits

Blender

Complete 3D suite — modeling, sculpting, rigging, animation, VFX, rendering & video editing. Industry-grade, 100% free forever.

100% Free

Win

Mac

Linux

FreeCAD

Open-source parametric CAD. Supports FEA, BIM & Python scripting. v1.1 (Mar 2026) fixed the long-standing topological naming problem.

Open
Source

Win

Mac

Linux

Tinkercad

Browser-based beginner tool. Boolean design, auto cloud save. Best for classrooms, hobbyists, and 3D print starters.

100% Free

Browser

MeshLab

Specialized mesh repair, cleaning, and processing. Essential for fixing 3D print files. Not a full modeler but invaluable for mesh work.

Open
Source

Win

Mac

Linux

Wings 3D

Lightweight subdivision modeler. Runs on under 100 MB RAM. Great for low-poly game assets and simple organic shapes.

Open
Source

Win

Mac

Linux

OpenSCAD

Code-first parametric modeler. Write scripts to define geometry — perfect for engineers and makers who prefer precision over visuals.

Open
Source

Win

Mac

Linux

Daz 3D / Hexagon

Free character-focused modeler. Sculpted primitives, figure content. Models export directly into Daz Studio for rendering.

Free

Win

Mac

VRoid Studio

Free anime-style character creator. Exports to VRM format for VTubing, VR, and game engines.

Free

Win

Mac

FREE WITH LIMITS — Freemium

Autodesk Fusion (Personal)

Full CAD/CAM/CAE suite free for personal use. License renewed annually. Advanced CAM, simulation & collaboration are paid.

Free
(Personal)

Win

Mac

Browser

Paid: \$680/yr

SketchUp Free

Browser-based with 10 GB cloud storage. Requires Trimble ID. No desktop format export on free tier.

Free (Web only)

Browser

Paid: from \$129/yr

Onshape Free

Full CAD system in browser — parts, assemblies, drawings. Free tier requires all documents to be public.

Free (Public docs)

Browser

Paid: \$1,500/yr

ZBrushCoreMini

Uses ZBrush's core sculpting engine, free. Limited brushes and export options. Great entry point for organic sculpting.

Free (Limited)

Win

Mac

Paid: ZBrush ~\$895

SelfCAD

Browser-based modeler with built-in tutorials. Free tier covers core modeling; advanced features need subscription.

Free (Limited)

Browser

Meshy.ai

AI text/image to 3D model. Free tier has limited monthly credits. Best for rapid game asset creation.

Free (Credits)

Browser

Spline

Browser-based 3D for UI/web. Free tier exports with Spline watermark. Popular with UI/UX designers for 3D web interactions.

Free
(Watermark)

Browser

Mac

PAID / PROFESSIONAL — Animation & Film

Autodesk Maya

Industry standard for film/TV animation, character rigging, and VFX. Used in virtually every major studio. 30-day free trial.

Paid

Win

Mac

Linux

\$1,785/yr | \$305/yr Indie

Autodesk 3ds Max

Industry standard for archviz and game asset production. Deep V-Ray/Corona integration. Subscription only, no perpetual license.

Paid

Win

\$1,785/yr | \$305/yr Indie

Cinema 4D

Best for motion graphics with unmatched After Effects integration. MoGraph toolset is unique. Perpetual license discontinued 2024.

Paid

Win

Mac

\$839/yr

Houdini FX

The only choice for procedural VFX and simulations. Used in blockbuster films. Affordable Indie license for freelancers.

Paid

Win

Mac

Linux

\$269/yr Indie | \$4,495 Perpetual

PAID / PROFESSIONAL — Sculpting

ZBrush

Unmatched for organic sculpting, character design & 3D printing. PolyPaint allows direct high-res surface painting. Perpetual license available.

Paid

Win

Mac

~\$895 one-time

Mudbox

Autodesk's digital sculpting tool. Integrates tightly with Maya & 3ds Max. Good for texture painting and detailed character work.

Paid

Win

Mac

Included with Maya sub

PAID / PROFESSIONAL — CAD / Engineering / Architecture

Rhino 3D (Rhinoceros)

Best for complex NURBS surfaces — jewelry, industrial design, architecture. One of few pro tools still with perpetual licensing.

Paid

Win

Mac

\$995 perpetual

SOLIDWORKS

Industry standard for mechanical and product engineering. Parametric design, simulation, and PLM integration.

Paid

Win

~\$4,000+/yr

SketchUp Pro / Studio

Architectural modeling powerhouse. Pro adds desktop exports and LayOut documentation. Studio includes V-Ray rendering.

Paid

Win

Mac

\$399/yr (Pro)

Onshape Professional

Full browser-based CAD with private documents, version control, and team collaboration. No install ever required.

Paid

Browser

\$1,500/yr

PAID / PROFESSIONAL — Texturing & Materials

Adobe Substance 3D

Industry standard for texturing and materials. Includes Painter, Designer, Sampler & Stager. Pairs with every major 3D app.

Paid

Win

Mac

\$599/yr (Indie)

Maxon One Bundle

All-in-one bundle: Cinema 4D + ZBrush + Redshift renderer + Red Giant. Best value for the full Maxon ecosystem.

Paid Bundle

Win

Mac

\$1,265/yr

Green = fully free/open source • Orange = free tier with restrictions • Pink = paid/professional • Prices approximate and subject to change.